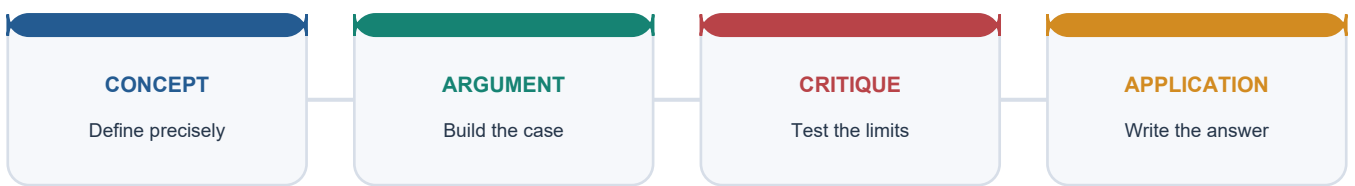


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Sāṃkhya - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section B | 32 diagnostics, 13 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Sāṃkhya - Solved Practice Workbook

How to use this workbook. Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed independently for each question from a randomised draw, so no rotation or predictable sequence can be exploited. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The solved previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.

Contents. 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial drills, then 13 solved previous-year questions - ten primary-owned by syllabus item 16 and three routed here because Sāṃkhya's causal doctrine is the subject under examination - followed by six original solved Mains models at 2 x 10, 2 x 15 and 2 x 20 marks.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct position was fixed **independently for each question** from a randomised draw, so there is no rotation, cycle or seed-derived sequence to exploit; the four positions occur eight times each and twice in every consecutive block of eight, and no position repeats on consecutive questions. Option length, specificity, grammar and formatting are balanced so that the correct answer is not visually identifiable. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

Composition: 24 core diagnostics (items 1-24) covering all fifteen teaching sessions, then 8 remedial drills (items 25-32) targeting the errors this topic reliably produces.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS

MCQ 1. Why the system begins from suffering

Consider the following statements about the starting point of Sāṃkhya inquiry.

1. Affliction is classified as internal, as caused by other beings and the material surroundings, and as attributed to cosmic or unseen agencies.
2. Scripturally promised results are rejected as false rather than as exhaustible.
3. The remedy the system seeks must correct a misidentification rather than manufacture a state.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 3 only, because ritual results are graded as perishable rather than false B. Statements 2 and 3 only, since Sāṃkhya treats every Vedic promise as an outright fabrication C. Statement 1 only, because the required remedy is an action performed with detached intention D. All three statements, as the school denies any efficacy whatever to visible or ritual means

Answer: A. Statements 1 and 3 only, because ritual results are graded as perishable rather than false

- **A:** Correct - the threefold classification is stated exactly as in statement 1, and the demand for a non-productive remedy is what makes liberation cognitive rather than active.
- **B:** Wrong on statement 2: Sāṃkhya grades ritual means as incomplete and exhaustible because a produced result is perishable; it does not call them fabrications.
- **C:** Wrong twice: it drops the correct statement 3, and it replaces discriminative knowledge with detached action, which is a Bhagavad-gītā formula and not the Sāṃkhya remedy.
- **D:** Wrong because it endorses statement 2; the school allows visible and ritual means real but partial efficacy within the field of nature.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates upgrade "incomplete and exhaustible" into "false", which converts a graded critique of ritual means into a blanket rejection the school never makes.

MCQ 2. Which text controls the classical position

Which statement about the textual identity of classical Sāṃkhya is accurate?

A. Kapila's own foundational work is extant and supplies the school's controlling formulations B. The *Sāṃkhyapravacana-sūtra* is the earliest systematic text and fixes the classical doctrine C. Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattvakaumudī* is the earliest extant systematic statement of the system D. Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṃkhyakārikā* is the earliest extant systematic classical text of the school

Answer: D. Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Sāṃkhyakārikā is the earliest extant systematic classical text of the school

- **A:** Kapila is the traditional founder, but the foundational works of the Kapila-Āsuri-Pañcaśikha lineage are not extant in securely recoverable form and cannot be quoted.
- **B:** The *Sāṃkhyapravacana-sūtra* belongs to a later textual phase, associated with more theistic readings, and must never be projected back into the classical system.
- **C:** The *Tattvakaumudī* is a major commentary on the *Kārikā* and therefore presupposes it; a commentary cannot be the earliest systematic statement.
- **D:** Correct - the *Kārikā* is the classical baseline, with Gauḍapāda's commentary and Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattvakaumudī* as its major explanatory traditions.

Examiner trap 2: A later theistic commentary is cited as evidence about the classical position, which quietly deletes the non-theism that the *Kārikā* system deliberately argues for.

MCQ 3. The exhaustive set of instruments of knowledge

Which set exhausts the means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*) admitted by classical Sāṃkhya?

A. Perception (*pratyakṣa*), inference (*anumāna*) and reliable testimony (*āptavacana* or *śabda*) B. Perception, inference, comparison (*upamāna*) and reliable testimony, as in classical Nyāya C. Perception and inference alone, as in the Buddhist epistemological tradition of two instruments D. Six instruments including postulation (*arthāpatti*) and non-apprehension (*anupalabdhi*)

Answer: A. Perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna) and reliable testimony (āptavacana or śabda)

- **A:** Correct - exactly three instruments are admitted, and all other candidates are reduced to or included within them rather than rejected outright.
- **B:** Four instruments including comparison is the classical Nyāya count; Sāṃkhya reduces comparison to inference or testimony instead of admitting it separately.
- **C:** Two instruments is the Buddhist epistemological count; Sāṃkhya retains reliable testimony because scriptural authority is available to an orthodox school.
- **D:** Six instruments including postulation and non-apprehension is the standard Advaita count; Sāṃkhya absorbs both rather than listing them.

Examiner trap 3: The Advaita six-instrument list and the Nyāya four-instrument list are transferred to Sāṃkhya, destroying the inferential burden that the three-instrument restriction creates.

MCQ 4. How the surplus instruments are absorbed

Match each candidate instrument with the Sāṃkhya reduction assigned to it.

Candidate	Reduction
1. comparison (upamāna)	P. included under perception's failure-conditions
2. non-apprehension (anupalabdhi)	Q. included in testimony when it becomes reliable
3. traditional report (aitihya)	R. included in inference or in testimony

A. 1-P, 2-Q, 3-R B. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q C. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P D. 1-P, 2-R, 3-Q

Answer: B. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q

- **A:** Misassigns comparison to the failure-conditions of perception, which is the treatment reserved for non-apprehension, and leaves traditional report in the wrong column.
- **B:** Correct - similarity works through a prior verbal report applied inferentially; non-perception means the conditions for perceiving are absent; and mere tradition counts only once it is trustworthy.
- **C:** Reverses the entire mapping, treating comparison as testimony-dependent only and non-apprehension as inferential, neither of which is the stated reduction.
- **D:** Places traditional report rightly but assigns comparison to perception's failure-conditions and non-apprehension to inference, reversing both of those.

Examiner trap 4: Non-apprehension is treated as an inference from absence, whereas Sāṃkhya locates it in the failure-conditions of perception and therefore needs no new instrument at all.

MCQ 5. Why the imperceptibility of the root does not refute it

An opponent argues that primordial material nature cannot exist because nobody perceives it. What is the precise Sāṃkhya reply?

A. Perception is not a means of valid knowledge at all, so its silence carries no evidential weight B. Scriptural testimony settles the matter independently, so no inferential defence is required C. Nature is perceived by the conscious witness directly, though not by the external capacities D. Non-perception can follow from subtlety, which is one of the standard causes of non-perception

Answer: D. Non-perception can follow from subtlety, which is one of the standard causes of non-perception

- **A:** Perception is the first admitted instrument in Sāṃkhya; denying its validity would collapse the school's own three-instrument scheme.
- **B:** Testimony alone would beg the question against a non-Vedic opponent, which is exactly why the argumentative burden is shifted to inference.
- **C:** The witness never perceives objects; it illuminates the intellect's operations, and nature remains beyond the senses for it as well.
- **D:** Correct - subtlety (**saukṣmya**) sits in the standard list of causes of non-perception alongside distance, organ-defect, obstruction and admixture.

Examiner trap 5: The reply is compressed into "it is inferred", omitting the causes-of-non-perception list that alone converts imperceptibility from a refutation into a datum requiring inference.

MCQ 6. Division of labour inside the inner instrument

Which statement correctly describes the functions of the inner instrument?

A. The coordinating mind determines and judges, while the intellect merely gathers sense-data B. The I-maker performs the final ascertainment and the intellect appropriates its results C. The intellect makes the final ascertainment, the I-maker appropriates and the mind coordinates D. All three functions are interchangeable names for a single undivided act of the mind

Answer: C. The intellect makes the final ascertainment, the I-maker appropriates and the mind coordinates

- **A:** Inverts the two decisive roles: the mind coordinates and synthesises sense-data, while ascertainment belongs to the intellect alone.
- **B:** Assigns ascertainment to the I-maker, whose sole function is appropriation as "I" and "mine", and reduces the intellect to a recipient.
- **C:** Correct - ascertainment (**adhyavasāya**) belongs to the intellect, appropriation to the I-maker and coordination to the mind.
- **D:** Collapses a threefold functional analysis into one act, which would make the derivation of the I-maker from the intellect unintelligible.

Examiner trap 6: The three inner functions are written as loose synonyms for "mind", which destroys the precise distinction the 2024 question explicitly demands.

MCQ 7. The two-way appearance

Consider the following statements about reflection in Sāṃkhya.

1. The insentient internal instrument appears conscious.
2. The inactive conscious witness appears to be an agent.
3. The witness undergoes a real modification when the reflection occurs.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 2 and 3 only, since apparent agency requires an actual change in the witness B. Statements 1 and 2 only, and the reflection leaves the witness entirely unmodified C. Statement 1 only, because the witness never appears to be an agent in any sense D. All three statements, as reflection is a real relation and therefore alters both relata

Answer: B. Statements 1 and 2 only, and the reflection leaves the witness entirely unmodified

- **A:** Statement 3 is false: a real modification of the witness would make bondage real, and a really bound changeless principle could never be released.
- **B:** Correct - the appearance is symmetrical and both terms are misdescribed, yet productive agency stays with nature and witnessing stays with the witness.
- **C:** Statement 2 is precisely what generates false appropriation, so excluding it removes the psychological root of bondage from the account.
- **D:** Endorsing statement 3 contradicts the changelessness that every proof of the witness presupposes.

Examiner trap 7: Reflection is described as an event that happens *to* the witness, whereas Sāṃkhya needs it to be an event that happens only in the transparent intellect.

MCQ 8. What "material" covers in this system

Which of the following is **not** an evolute of primordial material nature?

A. The determinative intellect, which is the first evolute and is predominantly luminous B. The coordinating mind, which arises from the luminous aspect of the principle of individuation C. The conscious witness, which is the twenty-fifth principle and neither cause nor effect D. The five subtle elements, which arise from the inert aspect of the principle of individuation

Answer: C. The conscious witness, which is the twenty-fifth principle and neither cause nor effect

- **A:** The intellect is the first evolute of nature and is placed in the "both cause and effect" class of the fourfold scheme.
- **B:** The mind belongs to the luminous line issuing from the I-maker and falls in the sixteen effects-only principles.
- **C:** Correct - the witness is counted twenty-fifth but is neither an evolvent nor an evolute; it stands outside the productive series.
- **D:** The subtle elements arise from the inert side of the I-maker and are themselves productive of the gross elements.

Examiner trap 8: "Material" is read as "physical", so intellect, ego and mind are moved out of nature and Sāṃkhya is misdescribed as a mind-body dualism.

MCQ 9. Which proof establishes that nature is one

Which argument for primordial material nature is the one that shows there can be only one such nature?

A. From the finitude and determinateness of things (bhedānām parimāṇāt) B. From the uniformity running through diverse effects (samanvayāt) C. From the distinction between cause and effect (kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt) D. From the undivided source of the diversified universe (avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya)

Answer: D. From the undivided source of the diversified universe (avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya)

- **A:** Reasoning from limitation establishes that a subtler ground exists, but several such grounds would satisfy the inference equally well.
- **B:** Coordinated diversity suggests a common material basis, yet a coordinated plurality of bases is not excluded by the argument itself.
- **C:** Distinguishing manifest effect from unmanifest cause fixes the stage-relation, not the number of unmanifest causes.
- **D:** Correct - since cosmic diversity forms one interconnected whole, positing many disconnected roots would destroy the undividedness from which the inference proceeds.

Examiner trap 9: The proof is named without the bridge sentence, so the answer states a conclusion the examiner asked to have *justified* and forfeits the reasoning marks.

MCQ 10. The textual reading of the third proof

The third argument for primordial nature is best rendered as an argument from which of the following?

- A. Purposive planning, which shows that an intelligent designer arranges the world-process
B. Operation due to causal power, since only a cause with the relevant potency can produce an effect
C. The testimony of scripture, which alone can establish an entity beyond the reach of the senses
D. The observed regularity of natural laws, which presupposes a legislating cosmic intelligence

Answer: B. Operation due to causal power, since only a cause with the relevant potency can produce an effect

- **A:** Reading the proof as planning imports a design argument, which would be fatal to a system that denies a creator.
- **B:** Correct - the standard reading of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15 is *śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca*, an argument from potency and operation rather than from intention.
- **C:** Testimony is admitted by Sāṃkhya but cannot carry this proof, since the point at issue is precisely what inference can establish against a non-Vedic opponent.
- **D:** Regularity requiring a legislator is a theistic formulation that the non-theistic argument from causal power is constructed to avoid.

Examiner trap 10: The variant reading *kāryataḥ pravṛtteḥ* is repeated, which turns an argument from power into an argument from purpose and converts non-theism into design.

MCQ 11. The three constituent qualities

Which pairing of quality, affective tone and evolutionary function is correct throughout?

- A. Luminosity-pain-concealment; activity-pleasure-manifestation; inertia-delusion-movement
B. Luminosity-delusion-movement; activity-pleasure-concealment; inertia-pain-manifestation
C. Luminosity-pleasure-manifestation; activity-pain-movement; inertia-delusion-concealment
D. Luminosity-pleasure-movement; activity-delusion-manifestation; inertia-pain-concealment

Answer: C. Luminosity-pleasure-manifestation; activity-pain-movement; inertia-delusion-concealment

- **A:** Swaps the tones of the first two qualities and gives movement to inertia, whose function is precisely resistance and fixation.
- **B:** Assigns delusion to luminosity, although delusion is the standing affective correlate of inertia in every canonical listing.
- **C:** Correct - the triad maps character, affective tone and evolutionary function together, which is what makes it simultaneously physical, psychological and ethical.
- **D:** Right about the first affective tone but wrong about all three functions, since manifestation belongs to luminosity and movement to activity.

Examiner trap 11: The affective column is memorised without the functional column, so the answer cannot explain why the same triad governs cosmology and psychology at once.

MCQ 12. Two kinds of modification

Which statement correctly distinguishes homogeneous from heterogeneous modification of the qualities?

A. Homogeneous modification occurs in equilibrium within each quality; heterogeneous modification generates the manifest evolutes B. Homogeneous modification generates the manifest evolutes; heterogeneous modification occurs only during cosmic dissolution C. Both kinds occur only after equilibrium is disturbed, since nature is entirely static while unmanifest D. Homogeneous modification belongs to the witness and heterogeneous modification belongs to nature

Answer: A. Homogeneous modification occurs in equilibrium within each quality; heterogeneous modification generates the manifest evolutes

- **A:** Correct - same-form transformation keeps nature dynamic while still undifferentiated, and cross-form transformation produces the differentiated principles.
- **B:** Exactly reverses the two, which would make the manifest world a feature of equilibrium and dissolution a period of active production.
- **C:** Denies that nature transforms while unmanifest, removing the reason Sāṃkhya can say dissolution is not annihilation.
- **D:** Assigns a modification to the witness, contradicting its changelessness and its exclusion from the quality-structure altogether.

Examiner trap 12: Only the table of the three qualities is reproduced for a question that asks for the qualities *and their modifications*, discarding half the printed demand.

MCQ 13. The status of the third proof for the witness

The argument from a presiding locus (**adhiṣṭhānāt**) infers which of the following?

A. An intelligent creator who arranges the psychophysical order from outside nature B. A cosmic mind that is itself an evolute of primordial nature and coordinates all beings C. A conscious witness in whose presence the unconscious system becomes an experienced order D. A permanent substance possessing cognition, volition and effort as adventitious qualities

Answer: C. A conscious witness in whose presence the unconscious system becomes an experienced order

- **A:** Reading the proof as a God-proof imports theism into a system that argues at length that no creator is required.
- **B:** A cosmic evolute would still be insentient, so it could not supply the conscious presence the argument is reaching for.
- **C:** Correct - the inference is to a presiding witness of lived order, and Sāṃkhya marks explicitly that this is not a proof of God.
- **D:** A substance with adventitious cognition and effort is the Nyāya self, which Sāṃkhya rejects because agency belongs to nature's evolutes.

Examiner trap 13: The third proof is presented as a design argument, so a non-theistic system is made to prove God in the middle of its own case for the witness.

MCQ 14. The nature of the conscious witness

Which description of the conscious witness is accurate in every element?

A. Consciousness is one of its qualities, and it acts, changes and produces the world for itself B. It is self-luminous, inactive, changeless, beyond the qualities, and a witness rather than a producer C. It is a conscious substance that really becomes bound and later really attains a new liberated state D. It is the material as well as the efficient cause of the world, though it remains unaffected by it

Answer: B. It is self-luminous, inactive, changeless, beyond the qualities, and a witness rather than a producer

- **A:** Treating consciousness as a quality would make it separable from the witness, and productive activity belongs entirely to nature.
- **B:** Correct - consciousness is the essence rather than a property, and every productive function is located on the side of nature.
- **C:** Real bondage and a really new state would both require modification, which the changelessness of the witness excludes.
- **D:** Nature is the material cause; making the witness a cause of any kind would destroy the division of labour the whole system rests on.

Examiner trap 14: Consciousness is described as an attribute the witness possesses, which quietly converts the Sāṃkhya witness into the Nyāya self with adventitious cognition.

MCQ 15. Source control on the plurality arguments

Which argument for a plurality of witnesses is **supplementary** rather than one of the three arguments of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18?

A. The fixed distribution of birth, death and the sense-faculties across different beings B. The non-simultaneity of activity, since beings act at different times and in different ways C. The differential constitution of beings by the three qualities in their temperaments D. The differential attainment of liberation, since some remain bound while another is released

Answer: D. The differential attainment of liberation, since some remain bound while another is released

- **A:** Fixed distribution of birth, death and faculties is the first of the three arguments that map directly onto the verse.
- **B:** Non-simultaneous activity is the second of the three verse-arguments and is regularly listed with the first.
- **C:** Differential constitution by the qualities is the third verse-argument and grounds the appeal to temperament.
- **D:** Correct - differential liberation is a standard supplementary inference and is not a fourth phrase in that verse; present it as reinforcement.

Examiner trap 15: A fourth argument is attributed to the verse itself, which is a checkable source error even when the philosophical content of the argument is sound.

MCQ 16. The Advaita objection to plurality

How does the Advaita objection to the plurality of witnesses proceed?

A. Every cited difference is a difference in limiting adjuncts, so at most many mental streams are proved B. Plurality is impossible because consciousness is inherently divisible into numerically distinct parts C. Plurality is unnecessary because Sāṃkhya could locate individuation in the subtle elements instead D. Plurality contradicts scripture, and Sāṃkhya therefore abandons the doctrine in its later phase

Answer: A. Every cited difference is a difference in limiting adjuncts, so at most many mental streams are proved

- **A:** Correct - bodies, minds and quality-configurations are adjuncts, and attributeless consciousness admits no principle of individuation of its own.
- **B:** Advaita holds consciousness to be partless and indivisible; divisibility is the opposite of its premise.
- **C:** Subtle elements are evolutes of nature, so relocating individuation there would still leave the witnesses undifferentiated.
- **D:** The plurality doctrine is retained throughout the classical school; no later phase abandons it on scriptural grounds.

Examiner trap 16: The objection is answered by simply repeating the plurality arguments, when the required reply is non-transferable bondage and release plus distinct reflected loci.

MCQ 17. The status of the empirical self

What is the metaphysical status of the empirical self (**jīva**) in Sāṃkhya?

A. A twenty-sixth principle standing between primordial nature and the conscious witness B. An evolute of the I-maker that possesses consciousness of its own in a derived degree C. The conscious witness as empirically conditioned through the intellect and the karmic stream D. A composite substance in which consciousness and materiality are really fused into one entity

Answer: C. The conscious witness as empirically conditioned through the intellect and the karmic stream

- **A:** Adding a further principle would break the enumeration of twenty-five, which is the content of the liberating knowledge itself.
- **B:** No evolute possesses consciousness in any degree; every evolute is insentient and only appears conscious by reflection.
- **C:** Correct - the empirical self is not a separate principle but the witness appearing through identification with intellect, ego, mind, body and karma.
- **D:** A real fusion would make bondage a genuine modification of the witness and would leave nothing for discriminative knowledge to correct.

Examiner trap 17: The empirical self is treated as a distinct entity to be enumerated, so the answer to the 2019 question loses the very identity claim it was asked to state.

MCQ 18. The order of evolution

Which sequence correctly states the opening of the evolutionary series?

A. Primordial nature, then the great one or determinative intellect, then the I-maker B. Primordial nature, then the great one, then the determinative intellect, then the I-maker C. Primordial nature, then the I-maker, then the determinative intellect, then the mind D. The conscious witness, then primordial nature, then the intellect, then the I-maker

Answer: A. Primordial nature, then the great one or determinative intellect, then the I-maker

- **A:** Correct - the great one and the determinative intellect are one principle under a cosmic and an individual name, and the I-maker emerges from it.
- **B:** Splitting the great one and the determinative intellect into two stages is the single most penalised error in this topic.
- **C:** Reverses intellect and ego; individuation presupposes the determinative function rather than preceding it.
- **D:** Places the witness inside the productive series, although it is expressly neither cause nor effect.

Examiner trap 18: The cosmic and individual names of one principle are counted as two successive evolutes, which also corrupts the total count of twenty-five.

MCQ 19. The fourfold cause-effect classification

In the fourfold classification of the twenty-five principles, how many are effects only?

A. Seven, comprising the determinative intellect, the I-maker and the five subtle elements B. Sixteen, comprising the mind, the ten capacities and the five gross elements C. Eleven, comprising the mind together with the five cognitive and five action capacities D. Twenty-four, comprising every principle other than the conscious witness itself

Answer: B. Sixteen, comprising the mind, the ten capacities and the five gross elements

- **A:** Seven is the count of principles that are *both* cause and effect, not of those that are effects only.
- **B:** Correct - one is evolvent only, seven are both, sixteen are effects only and one is neither, giving the standard 1 / 7 / 16 / 1 grid.
- **C:** Eleven counts only the capacities including the mind and omits the five gross elements from the effects-only class.
- **D:** Twenty-four is the total number of evolutes, which includes the seven that are also productive.

Examiner trap 19: The count of evolutes is confused with the count of effects-only principles, so the classification loses the discriminating work it was designed to do.

MCQ 20. What the active quality contributes

Which statement about the active aspect of the I-maker is correct?

A. It supplies energy to both lines of evolution and produces no separate set of principles B. It produces a distinct third series of principles alongside the luminous and inert lines C. It produces the five subtle elements, while the inert aspect produces the gross elements D. It ceases to operate once the two lines of evolution have been completely generated

Answer: A. It supplies energy to both lines of evolution and produces no separate set of principles

- **A:** Correct - activity contributes operative force to the luminous and inert lines alike, which is why the total remains twenty-five.
- **B:** A third product-series would inflate the enumeration and would leave the standard totals of the fourfold classification unexplained.
- **C:** The subtle elements belong to the inert line; assigning them to activity misplaces the origin of the elemental series.
- **D:** Activity is a permanent constituent of nature, present in every evolute in some proportion, and does not switch off.

Examiner trap 20: A third evolutionary line is invented for the active quality, which is the commonest way of arriving at a wrong tally of principles.

MCQ 21. Counting the subtle body

The subtle body is commonly counted as how many constituents, and which are they?

A. Seventeen: the determinative intellect, the I-maker, the ten capacities and the five subtle elements B. Thirteen: the three inner functions together with the five cognitive and five action capacities C. Twenty-three: every evolute of primordial nature apart from the five gross elements themselves D. Eighteen: the determinative intellect, the I-maker, the eleven capacities and the five subtle elements

Answer: D. Eighteen: the determinative intellect, the I-maker, the eleven capacities and the five subtle elements

- **A:** Seventeen results from dropping the mind out of the eleven capacities, which is the standard arithmetic slip here.
- **B:** Thirteen is the count of the thirteenfold instrument, a different functional grouping that excludes the subtle elements.
- **C:** Twenty-three would include the gross elements' predecessors indiscriminately and does not match the transmigratory vehicle.
- **D:** Correct - one plus one plus eleven plus five gives eighteen, with the eleven comprising the mind and the ten capacities.

Examiner trap 21: The mind is omitted from the eleven capacities, producing seventeen and quietly removing the coordinating function from the transmigrating vehicle.

MCQ 22. The strongest argument for the pre-existent effect

Which argument turns on the claim that sheer non-existence is featureless and therefore cannot discriminate between outcomes?

- A. Because what does not exist cannot be brought into being (asadakaraṇāt) B. Because everything cannot arise from everything (sarvasambhavābhāvāt) C. Because the effect has the being of its material cause (kāraṇa-bhāvāt) D. Because a determinate material cause is actually taken up (upādāna-grahaṇāt)

Answer: B. Because everything cannot arise from everything (sarvasambhavābhāvāt)

- **A:** This argument denies that a non-entity can be produced at all; it does not turn on the indiscriminability of non-existence across cases.
- **B:** Correct - if effects were wholly non-existent beforehand, non-existence being uniform could not explain why curd arises from milk and not from water.
- **C:** This argument establishes substantial non-difference between cause and effect, exemplified by threads and cloth or gold and ornament.
- **D:** This argument observes that agents select determinate materials, which is evidence of restriction rather than an analysis of non-existence.

Examiner trap 22: The five arguments are treated as five paraphrases of one point, so the answer cannot identify which of them carries the weight in a given question.

MCQ 23. Real transformation against apparent transformation

What is the decisive difference between Sāṃkhya and Advaita on causation?

- A. Sāṃkhya denies that being can arise from non-being, while Advaita accepts production from nothing B. Sāṃkhya treats the material cause as conscious, while Advaita treats it as unconscious C. Sāṃkhya holds transformation to be real, while Advaita holds it to be apparent only D. Sāṃkhya denies any relation between cause and effect, while Advaita affirms strict identity

Answer: C. Sāṃkhya holds transformation to be real, while Advaita holds it to be apparent only

- **A:** Both schools deny production from sheer non-being, which is exactly why both can be placed under a broad pre-existence orientation.
- **B:** The positions are reversed: Sāṃkhya's material cause is unconscious nature and Advaita's ultimate is conscious Brahman.
- **C:** Correct - real transformation yields dualistic realism and apparent transformation yields non-dual idealism, and this is where the 2018 question turns.
- **D:** Sāṃkhya affirms substantial continuity between cause and effect; denying the relation altogether belongs to neither school.

Examiner trap 23: The pre-existence doctrine is claimed as uniquely Sāṃkhya, which loses the shared premise that makes the real-versus-apparent contrast philosophically interesting.

MCQ 24. What isolation is and is not

Which statement about liberation in Sāṃkhya is accurate?

A. It is the merger of the conscious witness into primordial nature at the end of the cosmic cycle B. It is identity with Brahman attained when the limiting adjuncts of the empirical self dissolve C. It is the destruction of primordial nature, which ceases to exist once knowledge has arisen D. It is isolation, the disentanglement of the witness once discriminative knowledge is steady

Answer: D. It is isolation, the disentanglement of the witness once discriminative knowledge is steady

- **A:** Merger into nature would place consciousness inside the very field the entire system separates it from.
- **B:** Identity with Brahman is the Advaita goal; importing it erases the distinctive Sāṃkhya result of aloneness.
- **C:** Nature is not destroyed; it merely ceases its binding performance for the witness that has seen through it.
- **D:** Correct - isolation is disentanglement rather than merger, and in the strict formulation the witness was never really bound at all.

Examiner trap 24: Isolation, release in Advaita and release in Nyāya are used interchangeably, although the three name three different goals with three different mechanisms.

REMEDIAL DRILLS

These eight items target the errors this topic reliably produces. Each is written against a specific mistake rather than against a specific session.

MCQ 25. Correcting a half-remembered position on the first evolute

A candidate writes: "Nature first evolves the great one; the great one then evolves the determinative intellect; the intellect then evolves the I-maker." What is the correct diagnosis?

A. The sequence is correct, but the I-maker should have been placed before the determinative intellect B. The sequence is correct in order, but the mind should have been inserted between the two evolutes C. The great one and the determinative intellect are one principle, so the sequence has one stage too many D. The sequence is correct, since the cosmic and individual principles are genuinely distinct evolutes

Answer: C. The great one and the determinative intellect are one principle, so the sequence has one stage too many

- **A:** Placing the I-maker before the determinative function reverses the derivation, since individuation presupposes determination.
- **B:** The mind arises much later, from the luminous aspect of the I-maker, and cannot be inserted before the I-maker exists.
- **C:** Correct - the great one is the cosmic name and the determinative intellect the individual name of a single first evolute.
- **D:** Treating them as distinct evolutes inflates the enumeration and contradicts the standard fourfold classification of principles.

Examiner trap 25: The two names are read as two ontological stages, so an answer to a question that explicitly asks for their difference asserts the very confusion being tested.

MCQ 26. Correcting an over-claim about the pre-existent effect

A candidate writes: "The doctrine that the effect pre-exists in its cause is unique to Sāṃkhya." What is wrong with this?

A. Advaita Vedānta also denies production from non-being, so the doctrine is shared rather than unique B. Nothing is wrong, since every other Indian school holds that the effect is newly produced C. The doctrine is in fact unique to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, which Sāṃkhya later borrowed it from D. The doctrine belongs to Buddhism, where dependent origination presupposes latent effects

Answer: A. Advaita Vedānta also denies production from non-being, so the doctrine is shared rather than unique

- **A:** Correct - what is distinctive is Sāṃkhya's *form* of the doctrine, namely real transformation as against apparent transformation.
- **B:** Nyāya does hold that the effect is newly produced, but Advaita does not, so the generalisation fails immediately.
- **C:** Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika holds the opposite doctrine, prior non-existence followed by a new beginning of the effect.
- **D:** Dependent origination dispenses with an enduring material root altogether and therefore cannot house a latent effect.

Examiner trap 26: Distinctiveness is claimed at the level of the general doctrine instead of at the level of the mechanism, which weakens exactly the comparison the examiner wants.

MCQ 27. Correcting a confusion of soteriological goals

Which pairing of school and technical goal is correct?

A. Sāṃkhya-identity with Brahman; Advaita-isolation; Nyāya-cessation of suffering B. Sāṃkhya-isolation; Advaita-identity with Brahman; Nyāya-cessation of suffering C. Sāṃkhya-cessation of suffering; Advaita-isolation; Nyāya-identity with Brahman D. Sāṃkhya-isolation; Advaita-cessation of suffering; Nyāya-identity with Brahman

Answer: B. Sāṃkhya-isolation; Advaita-identity with Brahman; Nyāya-cessation of suffering

- **A:** Exchanges the Sāṃkhya and Advaita goals, which are the two most frequently conflated terms in this part of the syllabus.
- **B:** Correct - the three names mark three different results: aloneness of the witness, non-dual identity, and the ending of pain.
- **C:** Assigns the Advaita goal to Nyāya, whose realist pluralism excludes identity with a single ultimate consciousness.
- **D:** Right about Sāṃkhya but wrong about the other two, since cessation of suffering is the Nyāya formulation and identity the Advaita one.

Examiner trap 27: The three goals are treated as stylistic variants of "liberation", so cross-school comparison questions receive an answer with no discriminating content.

MCQ 28. Correcting the mango-seed misstatement

A candidate writes: "Sāṃkhya holds that a fully formed miniature mango tree is spatially hidden inside the seed." What is the correct formulation?

A. The tree exists in the seed as an actual but invisible object of a subtler perceptual kind B. The tree does not exist in the seed at all; the seed merely has an external causal relation to it C. The seed contains no determinate capacity, and any material would serve given suitable conditions D. The seed holds the effect as a latent determinate capacity, and production is real transformation

Answer: D. The seed holds the effect as a latent determinate capacity, and production is real transformation

- **A:** An invisible actual tree is the caricature the school explicitly rejects; only the capacity, not the gross effect, is present.
- **B:** A merely external relation is the rival position of prior non-existence, which Sāṃkhya's argument from determinacy is directed against.
- **C:** Denying determinate capacity concedes that anything could arise from anything, which is the very consequence the third argument rules out.
- **D:** Correct - the formula to write is latent effect plus material continuity plus real transformation.

Examiner trap 28: The doctrine is defended in its caricatured form, which lets an opponent refute it in a single sentence and costs the whole rival-rejection half of the 2020 question.

MCQ 29. Correcting the boundary with Yoga

Which statement correctly marks the boundary between classical Sāṃkhya and Yoga?

A. Yoga rejects the plurality of witnesses that Sāṃkhya defends and posits a single universal self B. Sāṃkhya is non-theistic and theoretical, while Yoga adds God as a special witness and a discipline C. Sāṃkhya owns the eight-limbed discipline, while Yoga borrows the theory of the three qualities D. Both are non-theistic, and the only difference lies in their respective counts of the principles

Answer: B. Sāṃkhya is non-theistic and theoretical, while Yoga adds God as a special witness and a discipline

- **A:** Yoga retains the plurality of witnesses; what it adds is a special witness, not a single universal self.
- **B:** Correct - Yoga is a friendly amendment that keeps nature, the qualities and many witnesses while adding God, discipline and the yogi's perception.
- **C:** The eight-limbed discipline is owned by Yoga, not by Sāṃkhya, and the qualities are shared metaphysics rather than a borrowing.
- **D:** Yoga is theistic, so the schools differ on precisely the question this option declares them to agree about.

Examiner trap 29: Yoga's mind-field, afflictions and eight limbs are imported into a Sāṃkhya answer, which both wastes words and violates the syllabus division of ownership.

MCQ 30. Correcting the elemental correspondence

Which correspondence between subtle element and gross element is correct?

A. Sound-potential to ether, touch-potential to air, form-potential to fire, taste to water, smell to earth B. Sound-potential to earth, touch-potential to water, form-potential to air, taste to fire, smell to ether C. Sound-potential to air, touch-potential to ether, form-potential to water, taste to earth, smell to fire D. Sound-potential to fire, touch-potential to earth, form-potential to ether, taste to air, smell to water

Answer: A. Sound-potential to ether, touch-potential to air, form-potential to fire, taste to water, smell to earth

- **A:** Correct - this is the standard series, running from the subtlest potential and element to the grossest in strict parallel.
- **B:** Exactly inverts the series, pairing the subtlest potential with the grossest element and vice versa throughout.
- **C:** Shifts every pairing by one position, which breaks the parallel between increasing grossness of potential and of element.
- **D:** Scrambles the series without any ordering principle, and in particular separates sound from ether, the pairing that anchors the list.

Examiner trap 30: The list is memorised as five items without its ordering principle, so any disturbance of the sequence goes undetected in the exam hall.

MCQ 31. Correcting the meaning of the chief-opponent title

Why does Śaṅkara treat Sāṃkhya as his chief opponent?

A. Because Sāṃkhya is a materialist school that denies scripture, the self and moral consequence B. Because Sāṃkhya alone among Indian schools denies that the effect pre-exists in its cause C. Because it is the strongest rival system, closest in ambition and nearest in its causal doctrine D. Because Sāṃkhya's practical discipline attracted more followers than Advaita in Śaṅkara's period

Answer: C. Because it is the strongest rival system, closest in ambition and nearest in its causal doctrine

- **A:** Sāṃkhya is an orthodox school that affirms the self and moral consequence; materialism describes Cārvāka instead.
- **B:** Sāṃkhya affirms the pre-existent effect; the denial belongs to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika under the doctrine of prior non-existence.
- **C:** Correct - systematic completeness, the proximity of real to apparent transformation, and the shared appeal to a single ultimate ground make the contest direct.
- **D:** The designation records philosophical rivalry rather than popularity, and the practical discipline in question belongs to Yoga.

Examiner trap 31: The chief-wrestler title is read as an insult, so the answer supplies only Śaṅkara's objections and omits the first half of the question, which asks *why chief*.

MCQ 32. Correcting the account of transmigration

In classical Sāṃkhya, what transmigrates between gross embodiments?

A. The conscious witness, which carries its accumulated merit and demerit into each new body B. Nothing at all, since rebirth is a conventional description with no continuing vehicle behind it C. The five gross elements, which recombine to form the next body under karmic determination D. The subtle body, which carries dispositions and karmic tendencies into another embodiment

Answer: D. The subtle body, which carries dispositions and karmic tendencies into another embodiment

- **A:** The witness neither acts nor literally migrates; attributing a moral career to it would make bondage a real modification.
- **B:** Denying a continuing vehicle is closer to a Buddhist analysis and would leave Sāṃkhya unable to explain karmic continuity at all.
- **C:** The gross body produced from parental material falls away at death and is not the transmigrating vehicle.
- **D:** Correct - the subtle body, eighteen constituents conditioned by the intellect's eight tendencies, is what continues between embodiments.

Examiner trap 32: The witness is described as the transmigrating soul, which contradicts the inactivity thesis on which every proof of the witness and the whole account of isolation depends.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Wording discipline. Every previous-year question below reproduces the printed wording exactly, including the paper's own transliteration. Model answers are independent learner practice written to the stated word band and directive; they are never official keys.

VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - 13 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Ten questions are primary-owned by this syllabus item across 2018-2025; three further questions are routed here because Sāṃkhya's causal doctrine is the actual subject under examination even though another owner holds the question.

2018 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Printed question. Is Puruṣa one or many? Explain the Sāṃkhya position in this regard and give arguments in support of your answer.

Demand decoded. "Is ... one or many?" requires a verdict in the first line. "Explain ... and give arguments in support" requires the canonical arguments with their source status, plus a defence against the obvious rival.

Model answer (183 words).

Sāṃkhya holds that conscious witnesses (**puruṣa**) are many, and that their plurality is numerical rather than qualitative: each is equally pure, inactive, changeless consciousness.

Three arguments map directly onto *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18. First, the fixed distribution of birth, death and sense-faculties: were there one witness, one birth would be every birth and all would be blind when one is blind. Second, the non-simultaneity of activity: beings act at different times and in different ways, whereas a single self would make all embodied streams act together. Third, differential constitution by the three qualities, since beings differ as luminous, active or inert in temperament. A fourth consideration - that some are released while others remain bound - is a standard supplementary inference rather than a phrase of that verse.

Śaṃkara objects that every difference cited belongs to limiting adjuncts (**upādhi**), so at most many mental streams are proved. Sāṃkhya replies that bondage and release are non-transferable, and that reflection requires distinct loci in distinct intellects.

The argument is therefore strong morally and weak metaphysically: Sāṃkhya establishes that experience is non-transferable, but cannot state what individuates attributeless witnesses.

2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Printed question. How do the Advaita Vedāntins react to the Prakṛtipariṇāmvāda of the Sāṃkhya philosophy? How do the Sāṃkhyas defend their own position in this regard? Discuss.

Demand decoded. Two directed halves - the Advaita reaction, then the Sāṃkhya defence - held together by "Discuss", which asks for ordered exposition ending in a judgement.

Model answer (281 words).

Sāṃkhya's doctrine of the real transformation of primordial nature holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause and is genuinely manifested through the modification of the three qualities: in equilibrium each quality transforms homogeneously, and on disturbance the qualities transform heterogeneously to yield the manifest principles.

Advaita reacts on three fronts. First, an unconscious first principle cannot be the cause described in the Upaniṣads, where the source is spoken of as conscious and knowing. Second, an ultimate that really transforms becomes mutable, and a mutable principle is dependent rather than ultimate; the world's dependence is therefore better explained by superimposition. Third, Advaita substitutes apparent transformation (**vivarta**) for real transformation, so that Brahman is the cause without undergoing change, as a rope is the "cause" of the snake seen in it.

Sāṃkhya defends itself equally on three fronts. First, the selectivity of production is real: curd comes from milk and not from water, and only a real material continuity explains that restriction, whereas an appearance-theory leaves selectivity unexplained. Second, mutability does not disqualify nature from being ultimate, because nature is by definition the principle whose being is modification; the objection would tell only against a changeless ultimate. Third, treating the world as appearance purchases the immutability of the cause at the cost of the reality of bondage and release, which Sāṃkhya's realism refuses to surrender.

Both schools deny production from sheer non-being, so the dispute is not about the pre-existent effect but about the reality of the transformation.

The exchange therefore terminates in a clash of first principles: Sāṃkhya preserves the reality of the world and pays with a mutable ultimate, while Advaita preserves an immutable ultimate and pays with the ultimate unreality of the world.

2019 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Printed question. Critically discuss the metaphysical status of a Jīva and a Puruṣa according to Sāṃkhya philosophy.

Demand decoded. "Critically discuss" requires the distinction, its mechanism, and a stated difficulty - not two definitions placed side by side.

Model answer (186 words).

For Sāṃkhya the conscious witness (**puruṣa**) is the metaphysical reality: pure, self-luminous, inactive and changeless consciousness, wholly beyond the three qualities. The empirical self (**jīva**) is **not a further principle** in the enumeration of twenty-five; it is the witness as empirically conditioned through identification with intellect, I-maker, mind, body and the karmic stream.

The mechanism is reflection. The determinative intellect, being predominantly luminous and therefore transparent, receives the reflection of the witness; the resulting cognition generates false appropriation (**abhimāna**) - "I am the doer, knower, enjoyer". The insentient organ thus appears conscious while the inactive witness appears to be an agent. The empirical self is precisely that two-way appearance stabilised into an apparent person.

Two consequences follow. Bondage is misidentification rather than a real modification of the witness, and liberation is the correction of attribution rather than the destruction of an entity.

Critically, the account is elegant but exposed: if the witness is never really conditioned, it becomes unclear in what sense there was ever a problem for it, and Sāṃkhya's reply - that the problem was always one of attribution - clarifies the question rather than demonstrating an answer.

Printed question. Which Sāṃkhya proof for the existence of Prakṛti actually shows that there can be only one Prakṛti? Justify your answer.

Demand decoded. A single named proof, then a justification. Marks are lost by listing all five without discriminating, and by naming the proof without the bridging argument.

Model answer (272 words).

The proof is **avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya** - the argument from the undivided source of the diversified universe.

Sāṃkhya offers five inferences for primordial material nature. From the finitude and determinateness of things (**bhedānām parimāṇāt**) it argues that the limited presupposes a subtler ground. From the uniformity running through effects (**samanvayāt**) it argues from coordinated diversity to a common material basis. From operation due to causal power (**śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca**, the standard reading of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15) it argues that determinate production requires a potent source. From the distinction between cause and effect (**kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt**) it argues that manifest effects imply a subtler unmanifest cause.

Each of these four is compatible with a plurality of material roots. Several reservoirs could each be subtler than their products, each display internal pattern, each possess productive power, and each differ in stage from its effects. None of the four takes unity as its premise, so none can deliver unity as its conclusion.

The fifth argument alone does. It begins from the observation that cosmic diversity is not a heap but one interconnected whole, and reasons that a diversified yet undivided cosmos points back to an original source in which later differentiations are not yet separated. Admitting many disconnected primal materials would therefore destroy the very undividedness from which the inference proceeds.

Justification, stated as a bridge: the premise of proof five is the world's undivided interconnectedness, so plurality at the root would falsify the premise and not merely complicate the conclusion.

The verdict holds within Sāṃkhya's own inferential licence; a Nyāya atomist declines it by tracing interconnectedness to coordination among many causes rather than to a single origin.

Printed question. "A mango tree is grown out of a mango seed." How will Sāṃkhya system explain this process through their theory of causation by rejecting their rival perspectives?

Demand decoded. Two obligations. Explain the example through the doctrine of the pre-existent effect *and* reject the rivals by name. An answer without the rival-rejection half cannot score.

Model answer (357 words).

Sāṃkhya explains the example by the doctrine that the effect pre-exists in its material cause (**satkāryavāda**), in its specific form as real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**). The mango tree pre-exists in the mango seed not as a miniature gross tree spatially concealed within it, but as a latent determinate capacity in a material continuum; production is manifestation (**abhivyakti**) of what is latent, and the effect differs from the cause by state (**avasthā**), not by substance.

Five arguments support this. Because a non-entity cannot be produced (**asadakaraṇāt**), no operation yields oil from sand. Because a determinate material cause is taken up (**upādāna-grahaṇāt**), the cultivator selects a mango seed and not sand. Because everything cannot arise from everything (**sarvasambhavābhāvāt**), and non-existence is featureless and therefore indiscriminable, sheer prior absence cannot explain why this seed yields this tree. Because the potent produces only the producible (**śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt**), a potency directed at a determinate effect presupposes that effect as its object. Because the effect has the being of the cause (**kāraṇa-bhāvāt**), the tree continues the seed's material substance as cloth continues threads.

The rivals must now be rejected. Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika holds that the effect is absent beforehand as prior non-existence (**prāgabhāva**) and that production is a new beginning; it objects that Sāṃkhya equivocates between the absolutely non-existent and the merely not-yet-existent, and that the whole (**avayavin**) is a new substance with new properties. Sāṃkhya replies that a not-yet-existent effect must still be something determinate in the cause, else the operation has

no terminus, and that new properties are new arrangements (**saṁsthāna**), not new substances from non-being. Advaita agrees that being does not arise from non-being but makes the transformation apparent (**vivartavāda**); Sāṁkhya replies that an appearance-theory cannot explain why production is selective. Buddhism explains becoming by dependent origination without an enduring material root; Sāṁkhya replies that momentary series cannot ground the observed material continuity of seed and tree.

The objection that production becomes pointless is answered by manifestation: effort removes obstruction and supplies conditions rather than creating being.

The doctrine is therefore strongest as an argument about determinacy, and remains contestable only where an opponent grounds determinacy in relational potency instead of latent effect.

2021 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Printed question. Explain the Sāṁkhya view on three guṇas (guṇa-traya) and their modifications.

Demand decoded. Two halves of equal weight. The triad is the first half; the two kinds of modification are the second, and omitting them forfeits roughly half the marks.

Model answer (250 words).

The three qualities (**guṇa**) are luminosity (**sattva**), activity (**rajas**) and inertia (**tamas**). They are not three separable substances but three inseparable constitutive tendencies of one primordial nature, present together in every evolute in varying proportion.

Luminosity is light, clear and buoyant; its affective tone is pleasure and its function is revelation, clarity and manifestation. Activity is dynamic, restless and projective; its tone is pain and its function is energy, stimulation and movement. Inertia is heavy, obstructive and resistant; its tone is delusion and its function is concealment, resistance and material density. Because character, affective tone and evolutionary function are mapped together, a single triad explains physical constitution, mental state and moral temperament at once - Sāṁkhya's most economical achievement.

Their modification (**guṇa-pariṇāma**) takes two forms. In equilibrium (**sāmyāvasthā**) the three stand in exact balance and nature is unmanifest (**avyakta**); here each quality transforms within its own nature, which is homogeneous modification (**sarūpa-pariṇāma**). This preserves the claim that nature is never inert, so that dissolution is not annihilation. When equilibrium is disturbed in the presence of the conscious witness, the qualities enter asymmetrical relations and generate differentiated evolutes: this is heterogeneous modification (**virūpa-pariṇāma**), to which actual cosmological evolution belongs.

The disturbance is not a mechanical collision. The witness is inactive, so Sāṁkhya describes only functional activation in proximity.

The doctrine is therefore powerful as an account of qualitative variety and weakest exactly at its trigger: what converts homogeneous into heterogeneous modification is presence rather than causation, and Śaṅkara presses precisely this point.

2022 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Printed question. Examine and evaluate the proofs given by Sāṁkhya philosophy to prove the existence of Puruṣa.

Demand decoded. Two directives. "Examine" wants the internal logic of the proofs; "evaluate" wants a reasoned judgement on their force. Listing alone answers neither.

Model answer (194 words).

Sāṁkhya offers five arguments, all sharing one premise: the entire objective complex is unconscious, instrumental and presented to experience.

Aggregates exist for another (**saṅghāta-parārthatvāt**): body, senses, mind and intellect are complexes, and a complex functions instrumentally for a user distinct from it. The witness must be other than the qualities (**triguṇādi-viparyayāt**): the knower of pleasure, pain and delusion cannot be the same changing states that are known. Organised experience requires a presiding locus (**adhiṣṭhānāt**) - an inference to a conscious witness of lived

order, and expressly not a proof of God. Experience requires an enjoyer (**bhokṭṛ-bhāvāt**), since presented states demand a subject for whom they appear. Striving for release presupposes a liberable witness (**kaivalyārtham pravṛtteḥ**).

Evaluating them, their force is cumulative rather than individual. Each alone invites a deflationary reply - a Buddhist explains coordination by causal series and ownership by convention - but together they converge on the structural point that a domain of presentation without a subject-pole is not a domain of presentation at all. Their form throughout is general-correlation inference.

Their honest limit is that they establish a subject-pole, not yet an eternal, plural and wholly inactive one.

2023 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Printed question. "If Puruṣa and Prakṛti are two completely independent realities, then no relation between the two is possible." In the light of this statement make a brief presentation of Śaṅkara's criticism of Sāṃkhya dualism.

Demand decoded. "Brief presentation ... in the light of this statement" means the quoted relation problem must organise the answer, and the criticism must be Śaṅkara's, not a general objection.

Model answer (190 words).

The quoted statement isolates Sāṃkhya's contact problem: if the conscious witness is wholly inactive and primordial nature wholly unconscious, no intelligible real relation appears possible, yet evolution, bondage and liberation all presuppose one.

Sāṃkhya answers that the relation is mere proximity (**sānnidhya**), not gross contact: nature becomes active in the witness's mere presence. Two analogies support this - a magnet moves iron without deliberative willing, and a clear crystal appears coloured by a nearby flower without itself changing. The first explains activation by presence; the second explains apparent contamination without real change.

Śaṅkara attacks both. Even a magnet exerts force, so if the witness were genuinely like a magnet it would not be wholly inactive. The crystal may explain appearance, but it cannot explain the initiation of the world-process, since a crystal initiates nothing. He adds that an unconscious chief principle cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause, which is described as conscious and knowing, and that purposive evolution "for the sake of" the witness presupposes intelligence.

His conclusion is that the dualism is unstable: it must either collapse toward monism or admit a third mediating principle - a demand for further explanation rather than a refutation by assertion.

2024 · Q7(a) · 20 marks (10+10)

Printed question. Present an account of evolution of Prakṛti as propounded in Sāṃkhyakārikā. In this context, also explain the difference between buddhi, mahat and ahaṃkāra.

Demand decoded. An explicitly split question. The first ten marks are the complete evolutionary sequence; the second ten are the three-term distinction, whose correct answer is that two of the three terms name one principle.

Model answer (382 words).

Part one: the evolution of primordial nature. Primordial nature (**prakṛti**) is the unmanifest chief principle (**avyakta pradhāna**), one, unconscious and uncreated, constituted by the three qualities in equilibrium. In the mere presence of the conscious witness the equilibrium is disturbed, and heterogeneous modification of the qualities (**virūpa-pariṇāma**) begins.

The first evolute is the great one, also called the determinative intellect (**mahat / buddhi**). From it arises the I-maker (**ahaṃkāra**), the principle of individuation. The I-maker then evolves along two lines. From its luminous aspect arise the coordinating mind (**manas**), the five cognitive capacities - hearing, touch, sight, taste and smell - and the five action capacities: speech, grasping, locomotion, excretion and reproduction. From its inert aspect arise the five subtle elements (**tanmātra**), the potentials of sound, touch, form, taste and smell; and from these arise the five gross elements (**mahābhūta**) - ether, air, fire, water and earth - on the standard correspondence of sound to ether, touch to air, form to fire, taste to water and smell to earth. The active quality supplies energy to both lines and produces no separate set of principles.

Twenty-four evolutes plus the conscious witness give twenty-five principles. The fourfold classification controls the list: nature alone is cause but not effect; the intellect, the I-maker and the five subtle elements are both cause and effect; the mind, the ten capacities and the five gross elements are effects only; and the witness is neither.

Part two: buddhi, mahat and ahaṁkāra. The decisive point is that the great one and the determinative intellect are **the same principle** under two names: the great one is its cosmic aspect, the determinative intellect its individual or psychological aspect. Writing them as two successive stages is an error that also corrupts the total count.

The I-maker is genuinely distinct and is derived *from* that first evolute. Functionally, the determinative intellect makes the final ascertainment (**adhyavasāya**) - judgement and discrimination - and, being predominantly luminous and transparent, receives the reflection of the witness. The I-maker appropriates functions as "I" and "mine", and false selfhood crystallises there, which is why it is central to bondage. The coordinating mind, arising later, only synthesises sense-data.

The sequence therefore unifies cosmology and psychology: the equipment of knowing is itself a product of the known.

2025 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Printed question. Why does Śaṅkara consider Sāṃkhya Philosophy as his chief opponent (pradhāna malla)? Examine his arguments against Sāṃkhya Philosophy.

Demand decoded. Two halves again. "Why ... chief opponent" asks for the grounds of the designation; "examine his arguments" asks for the objections tested for force. Answers that supply only the objections lose the first half entirely.

Model answer (374 words).

Why chief. The title of chief wrestler (**pradhāna malla**) records systematic strength, not contempt. Three grounds support it.

First, Sāṃkhya is the most sophisticated non-Vedāntic rival at the level of ultimate explanation: it accounts for world, self, bondage, liberation and causation within one coherent metaphysical system, and is therefore near enough to require detailed refutation rather than dismissal. Second, its doctrine of real transformation (**pariṇāma-vāda**) is the nearest rival to Advaita's apparent transformation (**vivarta-vāda**); both deny production from non-being and both derive the world from an ultimate, differing only on whether the derivation is real. Third, both appeal to a single ultimate explanatory ground - Sāṃkhya to one unconscious primal material principle, Advaita to conscious Brahman - so the contest is direct rather than oblique.

The arguments, examined. Śaṅkara's first objection is that an unconscious chief principle cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause, since the scriptural source is described as conscious and knowing; "knowing-cause" descriptions exclude an insentient nature. This is powerful within a scripturally governed enquiry, though a non-Vedic opponent may refuse the premise.

His second objection is the contact problem: an inactive witness and an unconscious nature cannot intelligibly relate, yet the whole system depends on their relation. Sāṃkhya answers with mere proximity, supported by the magnet moving iron and the crystal coloured by a nearby flower. Śaṅkara replies that a magnet exerts force - so the analogy either fails or destroys the witness's inactivity - and that the crystal explains appearance but not the initiation of the world-process. This objection is the strongest, because the two analogies do different jobs and neither does both.

His third objection is teleological: if nature evolves "for the sake of" the witness, purposiveness appears to require intelligence. Sāṃkhya replies that purposive functioning need not be conscious planning, as milk flows for the calf; the reply preserves internal sufficiency but does not remove the pressure.

Verdict. Śaṅkara treats Sāṃkhya as chief opponent because it attempts, from an unconscious first principle, exactly what Advaita attempts from a conscious one. He rejects it because the ultimate cause must be conscious, teleology cannot rest on unconscious nature, and the witness-nature relation remains unstable - a demonstration that the dualism needs further explanation rather than a proof that Advaita is thereby established.

2021 · Q5(a) · 10 marks · routed

Printed question. Does the seed contain the tree? Discuss with reference to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.

Routing note. Primary ownership lies with Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, but the question is unanswerable without the Sāṃkhya position it is framed against, and the Sāṃkhya side must be stated accurately.

Model answer (188 words).

For Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika the answer is no. Before production the effect is characterised by prior non-existence (**prāgabdhāva**) in its material cause; production is a genuinely new beginning (**ārambhavāda**), and the resulting whole (**avayavin**) is a new substance inhering in its parts and possessing properties the parts lack - a cloth covers, whereas separate threads do not.

The question is framed against Sāṃkhya, which answers yes on its own terms: the effect pre-exists as a latent determinate capacity, since non-existence is featureless and cannot explain why this seed yields this tree, and since a potency directed at a determinate effect presupposes that effect. Sāṃkhya does not claim that a miniature gross tree is spatially hidden in the seed.

Nyāya's reply is that Sāṃkhya equivocates: it denies only that the tree exists as the tree beforehand, not that the seed is determinate. Determinacy is secured instead by the causal capacity of the material and by the exclusion of non-causal antecedents.

The dispute therefore turns on whether determinacy can be carried by a relational potency alone, or must be grounded in a latent effect - a difference of first principles rather than of evidence.

2022 · Q5(e) · 10 marks · routed

Printed question. Do you agree with the view that 'Vivartavāda is the logical development of Pariṇāmavāda'? Give reasons in support of your answer.

Routing note. Owned by Vedānta, but the question is a direct examination of whether Sāṃkhya's real transformation entails Advaita's apparent transformation.

Model answer (181 words).

I agree only partly, and the qualification carries the argument.

The claim is defensible in one respect. Both doctrines deny production from sheer non-being, so both belong to a broad pre-existence orientation; and apparent transformation can be presented as the result of pressing real transformation's own logic - if the ultimate must not be diminished by producing, transformation is best read as appearance rather than as real change.

It is indefensible in another. Real transformation is not an incomplete version of apparent transformation but a rival with opposite commitments. Sāṃkhya's cause is unconscious primordial nature and its world is a real evolute; Advaita's cause is conscious Brahman and its world is ultimately appearance. Sāṃkhya's mechanism is the modification of the three qualities; Advaita's is superimposition. Treating one as the logical development of the other therefore assumes the very Vedāntic premise - that an ultimate cannot really change - which Sāṃkhya explicitly denies by defining nature as that whose being is modification.

The view is thus historically suggestive as a description of Vedāntic self-understanding, but logically question-begging as a claim about entailment.

2023 · Q8(b) · 15 marks · routed

Printed question. Write a note on Nyāya notion of Prāgabdhāva (prior non-existence). How does this notion help Naiyāyikas in defending their position on causation against the Sāṃkhya view of causation? Critically discuss.

Routing note. Owned by Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika; the second and third clauses make Sāṃkhya's causal doctrine the subject under test, so the Sāṃkhya side must be argued and not merely named.

Model answer (296 words).

Prior non-existence (**prāgabdhāva**) is one of the four absences recognised in the Vaiśeṣika category-scheme. It is the absence of an effect in its material cause before production: beginningless but with an end, since it terminates precisely when the effect is produced. Every absence has a counter-positive, and here the counter-positive is the effect itself.

The notion does exact defensive work for Nyāya's doctrine that the effect does not pre-exist (**asatkāryavāda**). It gives a positive account of the pre-production situation, so production becomes the destruction of prior non-existence rather than creation from nothing; it preserves the reality of production, since something genuinely new begins; and it blocks the charge of arbitrariness, because determinacy is located in the causal capacity of the material and in the exclusion of non-causal antecedents rather than in a latent effect.

Against Sāṃkhya it grounds a dilemma. If the effect exists beforehand, the causal operation is idle; if it does not exist as the effect, Nyāya's position has been conceded, and prior non-existence names exactly what the effect then lacks. Nyāya adds that the whole is a new substance with properties its parts lack.

Sāṃkhya replies that a merely negative antecedent cannot discriminate outcomes, since non-existence is featureless; that production is manifestation (**abhivyakti**) and effort removes obstruction; and that cause and effect differ by state (**avasthā**) rather than by substance, so the operation is not idle.

Critically, prior non-existence answers the charge of creation from nothing but relocates rather than removes the demand for determinacy, which Nyāya must then discharge through causal capacity - the very notion Sāṃkhya claims is unintelligible without a latent effect.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Six original questions written in previous-year style: two at ten marks, two at fifteen and two at twenty. They are learner practice, not previous-year questions.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question. Explain why Sāṃkhya restricts the means of valid knowledge to three, and show how this restriction shapes its metaphysics.

Model answer (177 words).

Sāṃkhya admits exactly three instruments of knowledge - perception, inference and reliable testimony - and reduces comparison, postulation, non-apprehension, inclusion and traditional report to these three rather than rejecting them as worthless. Comparison operates through a prior verbal report applied inferentially; postulation is inference to the best explanatory condition; non-apprehension belongs to the failure-conditions of perception.

This restriction is not economy for its own sake; it creates an obligation. Both ultimates - primordial nature and the conscious witness - are beyond the senses (**atīndriya**), so perception cannot reach them, and testimony alone would beg the question against a non-Vedic opponent. Imperceptibility itself is disarmed by the standard list of causes of non-perception, in which root nature falls under subtlety (**saukṣmya**).

The whole evidential weight therefore falls on general-correlation inference (**sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa**), which alone can reach a term whose invariable relation was never observed directly. The five proofs of nature and the five proofs of the witness are precisely the shape this epistemology forces.

The metaphysics is thus epistemically driven - and correspondingly vulnerable if that inferential licence is denied, as Cārvāka denies it.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question. "Nothing happens to Puruṣa at liberation." Comment on this statement with reference to the Sāṃkhya account of bondage and kaivalya.

Model answer (180 words).

The statement is accurate in strict Sāṃkhya and is the best available formulation of its soteriology.

Bondage is non-discrimination (**aviveka**) between the witness and nature. The determinative intellect, being transparent, receives the reflection of consciousness, and false appropriation (**abhimāna**) follows - "I am the doer, knower, enjoyer". Since this is misattribution and not modification, the witness is not really altered by bondage.

Liberation is correspondingly cognitive. Discriminative knowledge (**viveka-jñāna**) stabilises the distinction between witness-consciousness and quality-evolutes, false identification ends, and the resulting state is isolation (**kaivalya**) -

disentanglement, not merger and not annihilation. The canonical image is the dancer who retires once she has been seen; the potter's wheel explains why the body continues by prior momentum, giving liberation while living (**jīvanmukti**) before final release (**videhamukti**).

The strict formulation follows: the witness is never really bound, liberated or transmigrating, since these belong to nature and the subtle body.

The comment must end with the cost. If nothing happens to the witness, the school must explain in what sense the problem was ever *its* problem - a clarification it offers but does not demonstrate.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question. Examine the claim that Sāṃkhya's theory of the three qualities makes cosmology and psychology a single subject.

Model answer (270 words).

The claim is substantially correct and identifies Sāṃkhya's most economical achievement, though it must be stated with care.

The three qualities are luminosity, activity and inertia: not three substances but three inseparable constitutive tendencies of one nature, present together in every evolute in varying proportion. Each is defined simultaneously along three registers - character, affective tone and evolutionary function. Luminosity is buoyant, carries pleasure and performs manifestation; activity is restless, carries pain and performs movement; inertia is heavy, carries delusion and performs concealment.

Because a single triad is defined across physical, affective and functional registers at once, the same explanatory apparatus accounts for the density of a stone, the dullness of a mind and the confusion of a temperament. The evolutionary sequence completes the unification: intellect, I-maker, mind and the ten capacities are evolutes of the same nature that yields the subtle and gross elements, so the equipment of knowing is itself a product of the known.

Two qualifications are needed. First, the unification is achieved by placing all mental functioning inside unconscious nature, which is why Sāṃkhya is a consciousness-nature dualism and not a mind-body dualism; the psychology it unifies with cosmology is a psychology *without* consciousness. Second, the unification does not extend to the witness, which is beyond the qualities altogether, so exactly one thing remains outside the single subject.

Examined, then, the claim holds for everything the qualities constitute and fails precisely at the point where Sāṃkhya's dualism begins. That is not a defect in the theory of the qualities but the boundary the theory was designed to respect - and it is also where the system's relation problem starts.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question. Critically examine whether the Sāṃkhya doctrine of many Puruṣas is proved or merely postulated.

Model answer (277 words).

Sāṃkhya argues for the plurality of witnesses rather than assuming it, but the arguments establish less than the doctrine requires, so the honest verdict is "argued, not demonstrated".

The case rests on three arguments of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18. The fixed distribution of birth, death and sense-faculties: one witness would mean one birth is every birth. The non-simultaneity of activity: beings act at different times, whereas one self would make all streams act together. Differential constitution by the qualities: temperaments differ as luminous, active or inert. A fourth consideration, differential liberation, is a supplementary inference and not a phrase of that verse.

These arguments share a form: they infer transcendental plurality from empirical non-transferability. That form is exactly what Advaita contests. Śaṅkara replies that every cited difference belongs to limiting adjuncts (**upādhi**) - bodies, minds and quality-configurations - and that pure consciousness, being without attribute, part, action or location, admits no principle of individuation; Sāṃkhya therefore proves at most a plurality of mental streams (**citta**).

Sāṃkhya's counter is that bondage and release are non-transferable and that the reflection model requires distinct loci in distinct intellects. This is a genuine reply, since Advaita must then treat bondage itself as adventitious and the

many empirical selves as apparent.

The residual difficulty is internal and should be conceded. If every witness is qualitatively identical, the school cannot say what makes them numerically many; plurality is inferred from non-transferable experience rather than grounded in a stated principle of individuation.

Critically examined, the doctrine is therefore well motivated and under-demonstrated: it is proved as far as moral and experiential individuality can prove anything, and postulated precisely where metaphysical individuation is demanded.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question. Analyse the relation between Sāṃkhya's epistemology, its theory of causation and its account of liberation, and assess whether the three form a coherent system.

Model answer (368 words).

The three parts. Sāṃkhya's epistemology admits three instruments - perception, inference and reliable testimony - and reduces all other candidates to them. Its causal doctrine holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause (**satkāryavāda**) in the specific form of real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**), effected by the modification of the three qualities. Its soteriology holds that bondage is non-discrimination and liberation is discriminative knowledge issuing in isolation (**kaivalya**).

How epistemology drives causation. Because both ultimates are beyond the senses, the entire evidential burden falls on general-correlation inference. That is why the five proofs of primordial nature exist at all - and the third of them, from operation due to causal power (**śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca**), is already a causal thesis. Determinate production is the datum from which the material root is inferred, and determinate production is what the doctrine of the pre-existent effect explains. Epistemology and causation are therefore two descriptions of one inference.

How causation drives soteriology. Real transformation makes the world a genuine evolute rather than an appearance, so bondage and release are events in a real order. But real transformation also places intellect, I-maker and mind inside nature, which produces the reflection model: transparent intellect receives the witness's reflection and false appropriation follows. Liberation must then be the correction of an attribution rather than the destruction of an entity - which is exactly why isolation is disentanglement rather than merger, and why the dancer image, not the prison image, is canonical.

How soteriology returns to epistemology. The fifth proof of the witness - that striving for release presupposes a liberable witness - makes the soteriology part of the evidence. The system closes on itself.

Assessment. The coherence is genuine and unusually tight: each part supplies a premise the next requires, and the enumeration of twenty-five principles is simultaneously a cosmology, a psychology and the content of liberating knowledge.

The incoherence, where it appears, is concentrated at one joint. The disturbance of equilibrium is attributed to mere presence, which is neither perception, nor inference from causal power, nor a real transformation - the three things the system otherwise relies on.

Sāṃkhya is therefore coherent as a system of explanation and under-determined at its point of origination, which is precisely where Śaṅkara concentrates his attack.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question. "Sāṃkhya purchases the inactivity of consciousness at a high price." Discuss with reference to agency, moral responsibility and rebirth.

Model answer (372 words).

The statement is correct, and the price is best displayed by following one commitment through three consequences.

The commitment. The conscious witness is pure, self-luminous, inactive and changeless consciousness, wholly beyond the three qualities. Every productive function belongs to nature. This is not an incidental thesis: it is what the proofs of the witness establish and what makes liberation possible, since a really modified witness could never be restored.

First consequence: agency. Agency must be relocated entirely to nature's evolutes. The determinative intellect ascertains, the I-maker appropriates, the mind coordinates - and all three are insentient. What we experience as conscious agency is the two-way appearance: the insentient organ appears conscious, and the inactive witness appears to be an agent. Nyāya objects that an agentless self is otiose and makes its own self a substance with adventitious cognition, volition and effort. Sāṃkhya's reply is uncompromising: ascribing agency to the witness is precisely the false appropriation (**abhimāna**) in which bondage consists.

Second consequence: moral responsibility. If the witness never acts, it cannot straightforwardly own a moral career. Sāṃkhya secures desert through the stable association of one subtle stream with one numerically distinct witness. But this is asserted rather than derived, and it inherits the school's deepest difficulty: qualitatively identical witnesses have no stated principle of individuation, so the very individuality that moral ownership requires is the thing least well grounded.

Third consequence: rebirth. Transmigration must be relocated too. The subtle body - eighteen constituents: determinative intellect, I-maker, the eleven capacities including the mind, and the five subtle elements - carries dispositions and karmic tendencies, conditioned by the intellect's eight tendencies of merit and demerit, knowledge and ignorance, detachment and non-detachment, power and powerlessness. The gross body from parental material falls away. The witness neither acts nor literally migrates.

Assessment. The price is real but the purchase is deliberate. Inactivity buys a clean separation of phenomenal consciousness from cognitive processing, an intelligible account of liberation as correction rather than escape, and a non-theistic explanation of bondage. It costs an unowned agency, an ungrounded principle of individuation and a rebirth without a traveller.

Whether the price is too high depends on the prior question the schools actually divide on: whether consciousness may be described as doing anything at all.